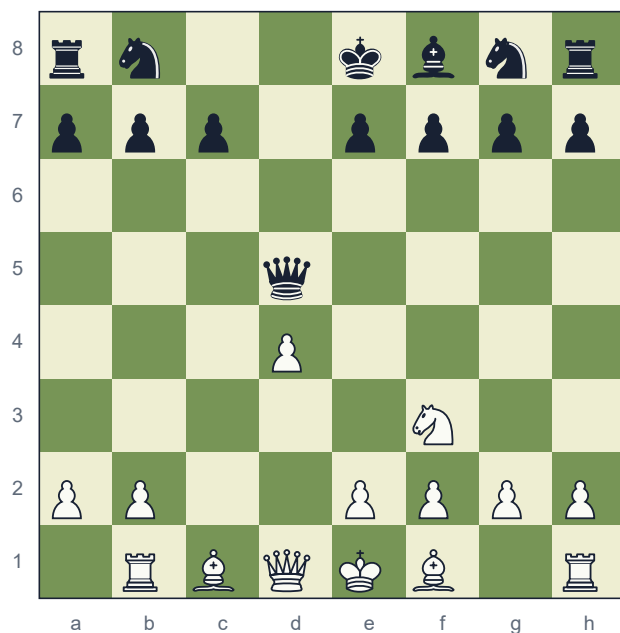


Other Queen's Gambit counters

1.d4 d5 2.c4: alternatives to ...e6, ...c6 and ...dxc4

YOUR REPERTOIRE CHOICE

Take the center and develop while responding to the actual threat. Several unusual defenses are playable; your task is a sound advantage or comfortable game, not an instant trap.



Main-line anchor - Black to move

THE PAWN STRUCTURE

Early bishops outside the pawn chain leave b7 or d5 less protected. Early ...c5 can create an open center where development counts more than pawn counting.

WHAT BLACK WANTS

The Baltic plays ...Bf5; the Marshall plays ...Nf6 before securing d5; ...c5 challenges the center immediately; ...e5 is the Albin covered separately.

THREE HABITS TO BUILD

1. Look for a tactical reason before repeating the standard QGD setup.
2. A queen exchange can be a practical response to an active-looking gambit.
3. Do not overextend merely because an opening is uncommon.

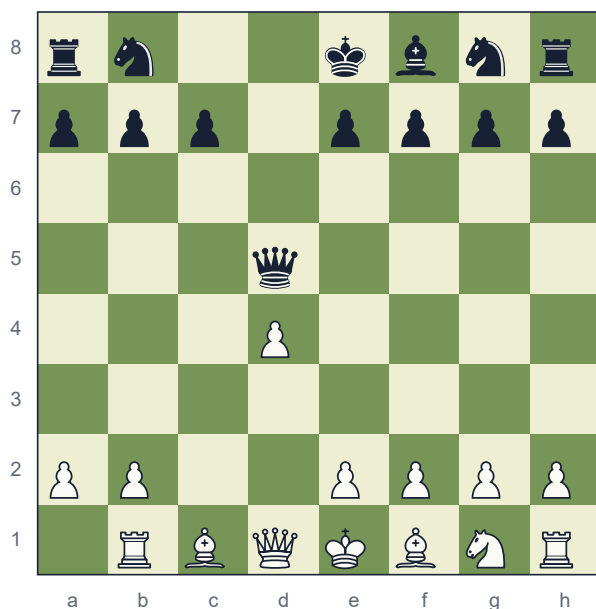
Line pages contain a selected opening anchor plus an illustrative checked continuation. They are not a forced script. Sources and method: Booklet 26.

01 Baltic: answer ...Bf5 concretely

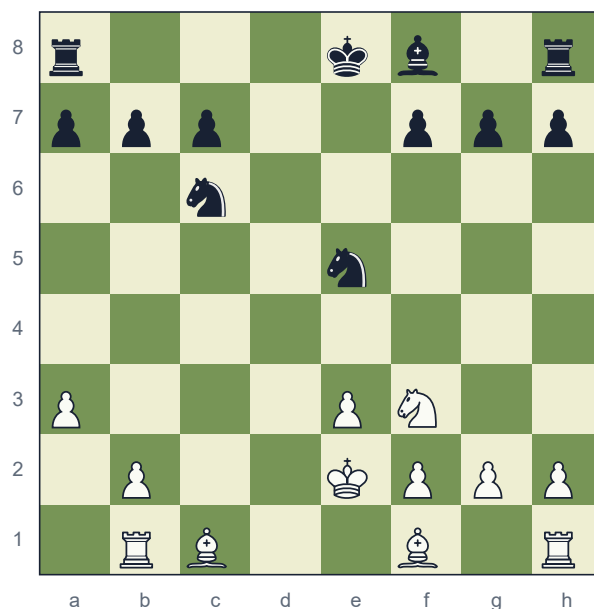
STUDY LINE 10-01

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bf5 3. cxd5 Bxb1 4. Rxb1 Qxd5 5. Nf3 Nf6 6. a3 Nc6 7. e3 e5 8. dxe5 Qxd1+ 9. Kxd1 Ng4 10. Ke2 Ngxe5

Selected anchor ends with 5. Nf3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

The rook recapture keeps your king and queen safe. Black recovers d5 but has exchanged an active bishop for your knight.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop e3 and Bd3 and bring the king to safety. The b-file rook may later pressure b7.

WATCH FOR

The rook on b1 does not mean you must start a queenside attack immediately. Finish development.

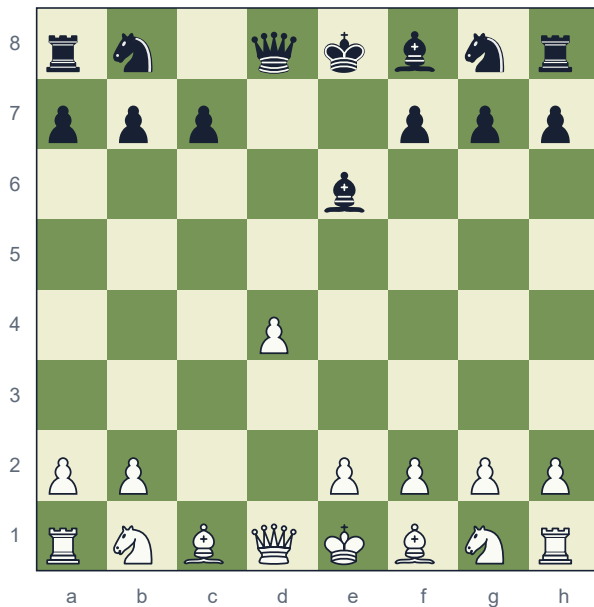
REMEMBER Accept the bishop pair and develop.

02 Baltic: Black recaptures with ...e6

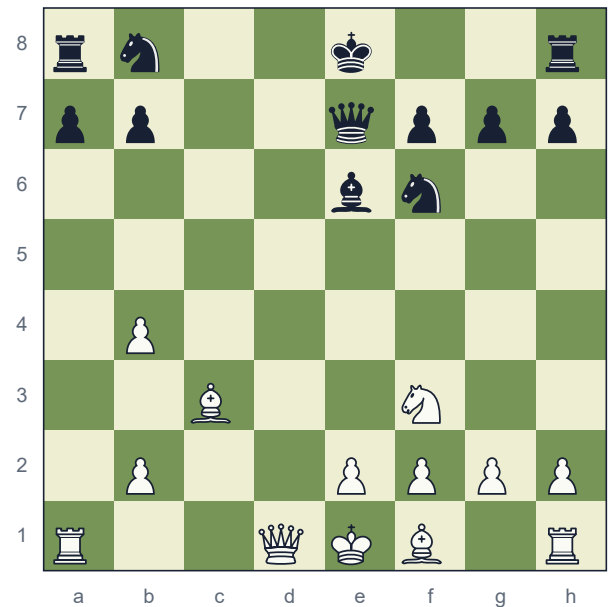
STUDY LINE 10-02

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bf5 3. cxd5 e6 4. dxe6 Bxe6 5. Nf3 Nf6 6. Nc3 Bb4 7. Bd2 c5 8. a3 cxd4 9. axb4 dxc3 10. Bxc3 Qe7

Selected anchor ends with 5. Nf3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

White accepts another central pawn while letting Black develop. The extra pawn must be balanced against the time spent capturing.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Use e3 or g3 as appropriate, develop the b1 knight, and castle. Be willing to return material if that eliminates a serious initiative.

WATCH FOR

Clinging to a pawn while leaving the king in the center can reverse the evaluation quickly.

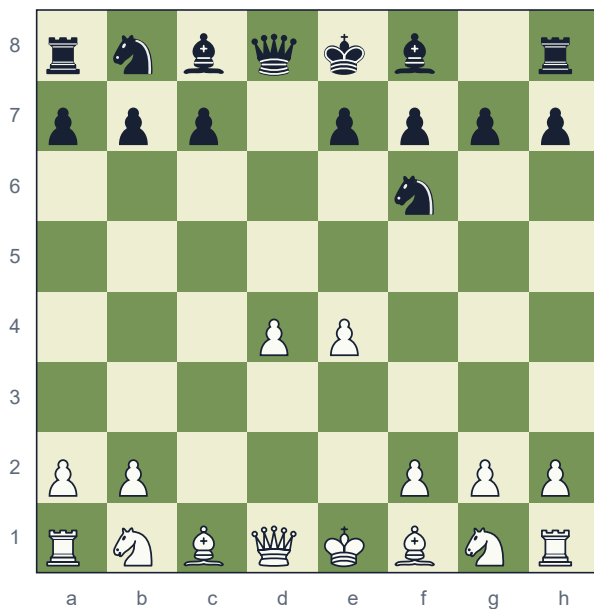
REMEMBER Material is useful only if your position survives.

03 Marshall Defense: ...Nf6

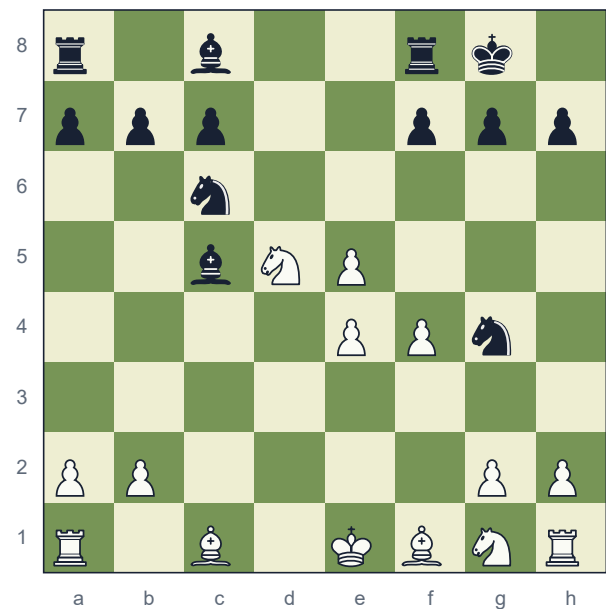
STUDY LINE 10-03

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nf6 3. cxd5 Nxd5 4. e4 Nf6 5. Nc3 e5 6. dxe5 Qxd1+ 7. Kxd1 Ng4 8. Ke1 Bc5 9. f4 Nc6 10. Nd5 O-O

Selected anchor ends with 5. Nc3. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 4 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

e4 builds a broad center with tempo against the knight. You gain space without chasing a queen around the board.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

Develop Nf3, bring out the bishops, and castle. Be ready for ...e5 or ...c5 to question the center.

WATCH FOR

Do not push e5 unless it improves your position; the existing center is already an asset.

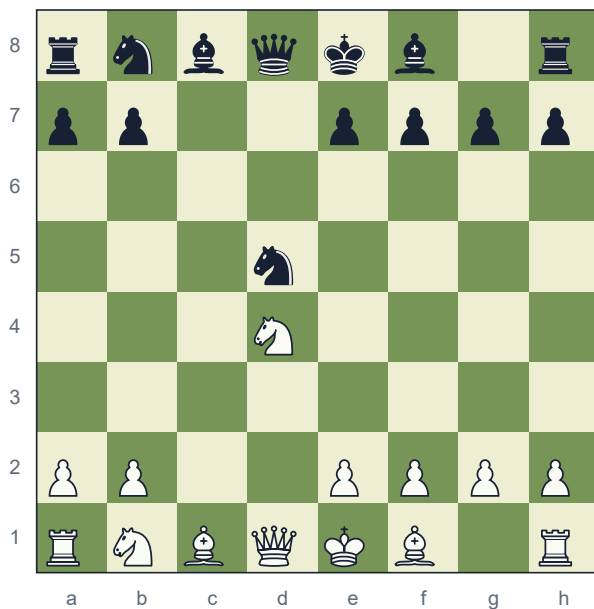
REMEMBER Build the center with tempo, then support it.

04 Symmetrical counter: ...c5

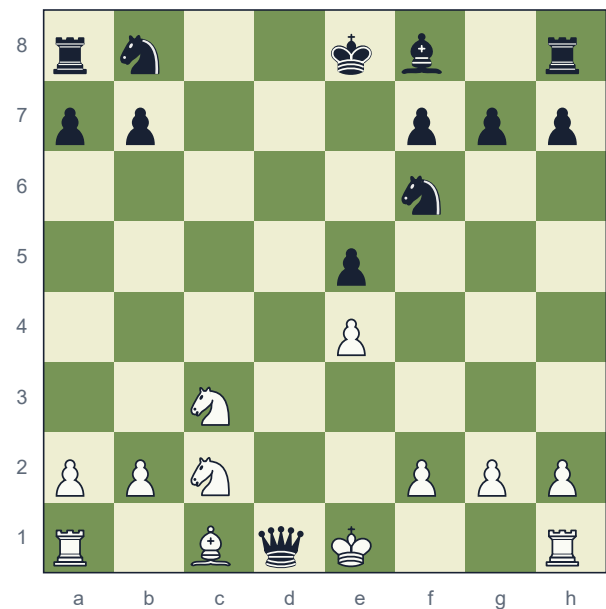
STUDY LINE 10-04

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c5 3. cxd5 Nf6 4. Nf3 cxd4 5. Nxd4 Nxd5 6. e4 Nf6 7. Bb5+ Bd7 8. Bxd7+ Qxd7 9. Nc3 e5 10. Nc2 Qxd1+

Selected anchor ends with 6. e4. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 5 - White to move



End of study line - White to move - in check

WHY THESE MOVES

Central exchanges produce an open position. e4 can gain space while attacking the knight on d5.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

First answer the check shown in the final diagram. Develop quickly and calculate queen checks before chasing knights further. Open files reward a castled king and connected rooks.

WATCH FOR

Do not assume all pawn captures are forced. An intermediate developing move can be stronger.

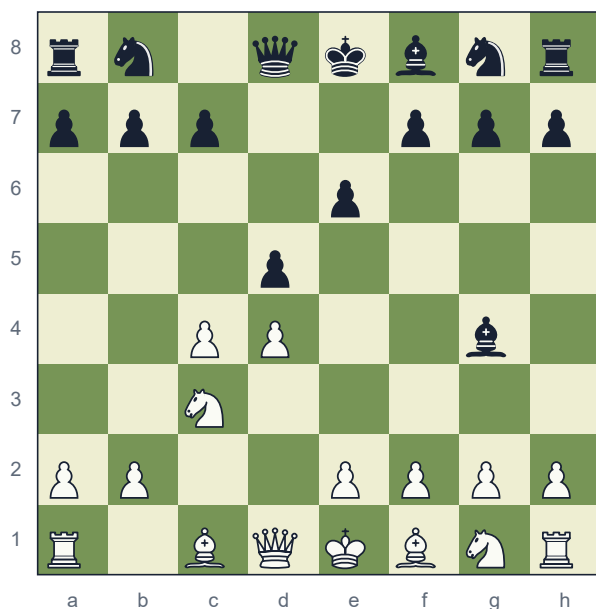
REMEMBER In an open center, count tempi as well as pawns.

05 An early ...Bg4

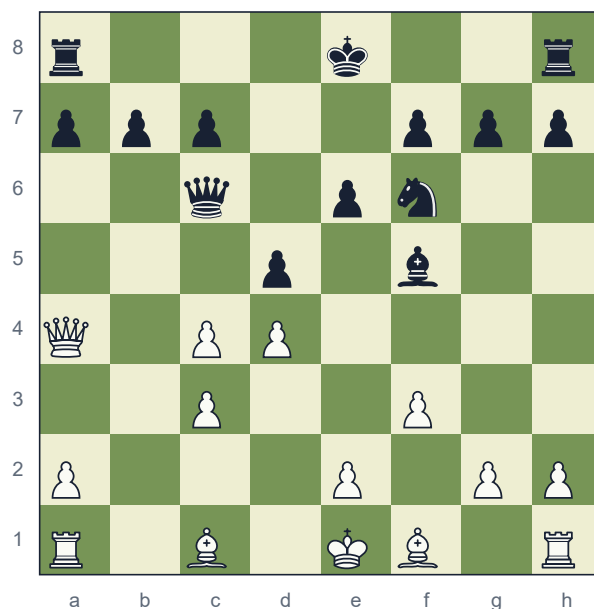
STUDY LINE 10-05

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bg4 3. Nc3 e6 4. Nf3 Nf6 5. Ne5 Bf5 6. Qb3 Nc6 7. Qa4 Bb4 8. Nxc6 Bxc3+ 9. bxc3 Qd7 10. f3 Qxc6

Selected anchor ends with 4... Nf6. Later moves illustrate one checked continuation.



Checkpoint after move 3 - White to move



End of study line - White to move

WHY THESE MOVES

Nc3 and Nf3 are useful developing moves. Black's bishop is active, but the center and b7 can become targets.

YOUR NEXT PLAN

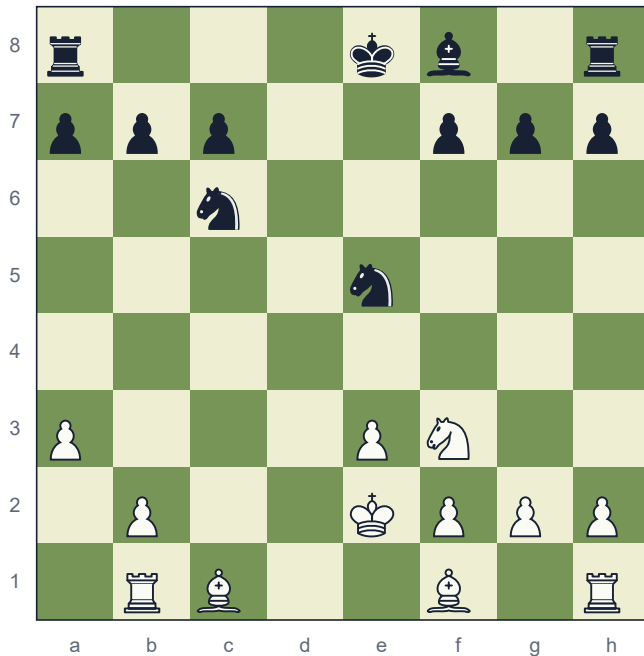
Choose e3 and a safe king setup, or question the bishop if there is a concrete gain. Use the actual central structure to select a plan.

WATCH FOR

Do not play f3 casually: it takes the natural f3 square from the knight and weakens the king.

REMEMBER Develop first; chase the bishop only with a reason.

Review before your next game



Main-line study position - White to move

1. IDENTIFY THE STRUCTURE.

Early bishops outside the pawn chain leave b7 or d5 less protected. Early ...c5 can create an open center where development counts more than pawn counting.

2. NAME BLACK'S PLAN.

The Baltic plays ...Bf5; the Marshall plays ...Nf6 before securing d5; ...c5 challenges the center immediately; ...e5 is the Albin covered separately.

3. CHOOSE YOUR NEXT JOB.

Develop e3 and Bd3 and bring the king to safety. The b-file rook may later pressure b7.

RECONSTRUCTION DRILL

Set up the starting position and play the main study line without looking. After each Black move, say what changed. If you cannot explain your reply, stop at that position and review the relevant line page.

DECISION DRILL

Return to the diagram. Write two candidate moves and a likely reply to each. You are not trying to guess the next engine move: you are testing whether your choices fit the structure and survive checks, captures and threats.

SELF-CHECK

Can you identify every capture and recapture in the line? Can you state one move-order exception? Can you explain the final position without using the opening name?

Related practice: Booklet 24. Use the matching line ID in the PGN companion. Opening names: Lichess public opening dataset; original course choices and analysis, checked with Stockfish 18.